

POL309: Politics of the European Union
Department of Political Science
Diego Hernandez

Course Information:

Why the European Union was created, how its institutions have evolved over time, and where the union is going.

This course offers a comprehensive introduction to the European Union (EU), exploring its political dynamics, historical foundations, and contemporary challenges. We will examine how the EU's evolving integration process influences current policies and debates, with an emphasis on the key actors, the motivations, and the mechanisms behind the construction of a collective Europe.

The course grounds these developments in theoretical frameworks relevant to comparative politics and international relations and is intended to help prepare students for advanced studies or occupations in European affairs, international relations, international public policy, or political science.

SBC Designation: SBS+ Social and Behavioral Sciences | Credits: 3 units | Pre-requisites, Co-requisites: U2 or higher standing; Advisory pre-requisite: POL101 and 103, DEC I | Required grade: A through D | Summer II, 2026.

This course is online and asynchronous, from 7/6/26 and 8/15/26. Asynchronous courses are flexibly designed to give students who may work during the days or have other commitments equitable access to university education. This course strives to help achieve that mission but does still have a structure. Students should expect to complete a video lecture of up to one-hour, textbook readings of up to two chapters, and one assignment or quiz per week. See below for assignment details, deadlines, and quiz schedule.

Instructor Information:

Diego Hernandez, PhD Student

Email: diego.hernandez@stonybrook.edu

Office hours by appointment, booked at:

<https://calendly.com/diego-hernandez-political-science/pol309-politics-in-the-european-union>

Course Objectives:

1. Describe the structure, roles, and functions of major EU institutions.
2. Evaluate how EU institutions collaborate and compete in the policymaking process.
3. Investigate major policy areas, including economic policy, internal governance, and the EU's global role.

4. Conduct independent research on member and non-member states and formulate arguments supported by factual evidence related to EU political dynamics.
5. Produce structured, analytical essays related to EU politics.

Required Course Materials:

Our textbook for this course is John McCormick's *Understanding the European Union: A Concise Introduction*, 8th edition (2021). Students are required to obtain a copy.

Recommended Course Materials:

Each week, I will be compiling a list of resources on the course's Brightspace that students may find helpful. Reading these sources is not required but they may be used as reference material in your course assignments.

How to Communicate and Interact in this Online Course:

Regular, professional, and respectful communication is essential in online classes. Review additional [Online Communication Guidelines](#) carefully and contact me with any questions you may have.

Response Time and Feedback on Assignments:

You should expect email turnaround time of less than 24 hours Mondays-Fridays. If you email me and I do not respond in less than 48 hours during the week, please send me a follow-up email. I understand the summer session is short, so I aim for fast turnaround times. On your assignments, from deadline to receiving your grade, expect that it will take a full week.

Grading Scale:

A = 93+
A- = 90-92
B+ = 87-89
B = 83-86
B- = 80-82
C+ = 77-79
C = 73-76
C- = 70-72
D+ = 67-69
D = 63-66
D- = 60-62
F = 0-60

Assignments:

Reading-Check Short Quizzes (15% of your grade, weeks 1, 2, 4):

To do well in this course, you will be expected to complete the assigned readings each week. There will be short weekly quizzes to assess how well you are understanding the material. These should be completed after reading everything assigned for the week and must be completed by Friday at 11:59pm.

Week 3: Writing Assignment (25% of your grade):

Please look through headlines on <https://www.euractiv.com/>, an independent pan-European media network specialized in EU affairs to get a sense of some of the issues that are currently evolving in EU politics. Your task is to write a 500 word (minimum) reflection on how the EU could address the issue. First, describe what's happening and who is involved. Then, **choose two** EU institutions from the videos I assigned, and write about how those institutions and their political actors may engage the issue you read about in the news. In writing the piece, you can be as creative as you want after providing these basics. You may, although it is not necessary, get into character as an EU official within your selected institution and explain what you and your institution can do to help address the issue. You will be graded on how well you demonstrate that you are familiar with the two institutions you choose to highlight. At the end of your short essay, include a link to the article on the Euractive website, and cite any sources you use.

Week 4 and 5: Individual Student Meetings (10% of your grade):

You must schedule an online one-to-one synchronous meeting with me to discuss your final paper in either weeks 4 or 5. In advance of this meeting, please formalize your paper ideas as much as possible. These meetings are to help you so that you receive a good grade and can produce a quality paper that you can potentially expand upon in work beyond this course. The earlier you schedule this, the better.

Final Paper (50% of your grade):

For your final paper, you may choose either of the below options:

Option 1: Select a current member country and discuss its history in the European Union, what the landmark events were that led to it joining, the reasons, etc. This requires doing research on your own. What do you think the future looks like for this country's membership? Are there any internal crises or movements in public opinion within this country, neighboring countries, or the EU that may threaten political stability? I want your opinion, but it needs to be backed up by facts, and you need to discuss the institutions, political actors, and processes of politics in the EU as you make your case.

Option 2: Select a current non-member country and discuss why the country wants to, or may want to, join the EU – or not. What are the benefits, what compromises would the country have to make to be granted entry? This option allows you to think about geopolitics, a Europe in the world. Same as above, you need to show that you understand the institutions, key actors, and the political process of the EU. You'll need to overview historical directions or events in the country's history to effectively make your argument.

Whichever you choose, write a typed paper in MLA or APA format, 6-7 pages, double spaced, size 12 font. Your paper must be submitted to Brightspace by Saturday, August 15th, 11:59PM, EST. You must substantially reference the textbook in your final paper.

Course Schedule:

The possibility exists that unforeseen events will make schedule changes necessary. Any changes will be clearly noted in Brightspace Announcements and through Stony Brook email. Please ensure your notifications are turned on in Brightspace settings, so you receive announcements promptly.

An asterisk () denotes a week with an assignment due.*

Week 1: *The Idea of Europe, the Foundation of the Union:*

1. Chapter 2, “The Idea of Europe” in McCormick’s *Understanding the European Union*.
2. Watch (until 9:50 mark): *The Idea of Europe: An Introduction to the European Institute*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ad5U253ik-s>.

Week 2: *The Political History of the European Union:*

1. Chapter 3 “The Evolution of the EU”
2. Chapter 1 “What is the European Union”

Note: Please read the third chapter first. In the first chapter, McCormick discusses how the EU is politically structured, which we will get into after we discuss its history this week.

Week 3: *Institutions of the European Union:

1. Chapter 4, “The European Institutions”
2. Chapter 6, “The EU Policy Process”
3. Watch the videos below:
 - a. European Commission: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nZqG4U-X1_s
 - b. European Council: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Y4xzsOvybA>
 - c. Council of the European Union: https://youtu.be/_CxrVizxlGA?si=T-IDsDimFFc_QXBO
 - d. European Parliament: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WoGvVUtRnoU>
 - e. EU Financial System: <https://youtu.be/QsLOm9vU1bA?si=IjLVZqcVrE6lgWwn>
 - f. EU Laws: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8C0Kq7ioOpk>

Week 4: *The Single Market and a Diversity of Opinions:*

1. Chapter 7, “Economic Policy”
2. Chapter 5, “The EU and its Citizens”

Schedule a meeting with me this week or next

Week 5: *The Politics of Crisis and Europe’s Response:*

1. Chapter 8, “Internal Policies”
2. Chapter 9, “The EU in the World”

****Week 6: Final Papers Due August 15th at 11:59PM.***

Wellness & Support Statement:

Stony Brook values student well-being, including mental health, and recognizes that a variety of factors can impact emotional wellness and academic success including stress, anxiety, depression, substance use, sexual violence, family or relationship concerns, and political conflict. [Resources are available](#) if you experience challenges or wellness concerns that affect your ability to be successful in class, and you are encouraged to reach out for help when you need it.

In the event of a short-term absence from class, students are encouraged to communicate immediately and work directly with instructors. However, if a student is struggling with an extended absence due a hospitalization, family illness or death, they are encouraged to reach out to the Student Support Team.

Privacy Policies:

This course utilizes various educational technologies to enhance the learning experience. You can access links to the [privacy policies](#) of the tools and platforms used at Stony Brook University on the Syllabus Addendum webpage.

Course Policies:

Plagiarism and cheating are breaches of the standard codes of academic honesty, offenses that will be treated very seriously. Copying or appropriating someone else's work or handing in work previously graded constitutes academic dishonesty, as does submitting work generated by LLMs or AI. Your work will be carefully assessed for originality. Do not try it. Academic dishonesty and cheating will be pursued with disciplinary action and will result in an "F" grade for the course.

Do Not Use AI Text in Your Writing:

Submitting text you did not write for a grade is plagiarism. Do not use text generated by artificial intelligence such as ChatGPT, Claude, or other, similar tools. Do not use online pay-for-product writing services. The text in your papers and presentations must be written by you. AI services generate text that fits patterns and often does not provide quality output. If you use AI, I will catch it.

Late Work Policy:

Late assignments will be subject to 5% penalty per day, including Saturdays and Sundays. Assignments which are more than a week late may not be accepted.

Attendance Policy:

Attendance in an online asynchronous course will be tracked differently than in a course that meets at set days/times throughout the semester. Attendance is tracked through your timely participation in certain course activities. Logging in to the course platform alone does not count as attendance. If you do not engage in the course, you will be considered "absent".

University Policies:

Student Accessibility Support Center Statement:

If you have a physical, psychological, medical, or learning disability that may impact your course work, please contact the Student Accessibility Support Center, Stony Brook Union Suite 107, (631) 632-6748, or at sasc@stonybrook.edu. They will determine with you what accommodations are necessary and appropriate. All information and documentation is confidential.

Students who require assistance during emergency evacuation are encouraged to discuss their needs with their professors and the Student Accessibility Support Center. For procedures and information go to the following website: <https://ehs.stonybrook.edu//programs/fire-safety/emergency-evacuation/evacuation-guide-disabilities> and search Fire Safety and Evacuation and Disabilities.

Academic Integrity Statement:

Each student must pursue his or her academic goals honestly and be personally accountable for all submitted work. Representing another person's work as your own is always wrong. Faculty is required to report any suspected instances of academic dishonesty to the Academic Judiciary. Faculty in the Health Sciences Center (School of Health Professions, Nursing, Social Welfare, Dental Medicine) and School of Medicine are required to follow their school-specific procedures. For more comprehensive information on academic integrity, including categories of academic dishonesty please refer to the academic judiciary website at http://www.stonybrook.edu/commcms/academic_integrity/index.html

Critical Incident Management:

Stony Brook University expects students to respect the rights, privileges, and property of other people. Faculty are required to report to the Office of Student Conduct and Community Standards any disruptive behavior that interrupts their ability to teach, compromises the safety of the learning environment, or inhibits students' ability to learn. Faculty in the HSC Schools and the School of Medicine are required to follow their school-specific procedures. Further information about most academic matters can be found in the Undergraduate Bulletin, the Undergraduate Class Schedule, and the Faculty-Employee Handbook.

Understand When You May Drop This Course:

If you need to drop or withdraw from the course, it is your responsibility to be aware of the tuition liability deadlines listed on the registrar's [Academic Calendar](#). Before making the decision to drop/withdraw you may want to contact me or refer to the University's policies:

- [Undergraduate Course Load and Course Withdrawal Policy](#)

Incomplete Policy:

Under emergency/special circumstances, students may petition for an incomplete grade. Circumstances must be documented and significant enough to merit an incomplete. If you need

to request an incomplete for this course, contact me for approval as far in advance as possible.
You should also read the University's policies that apply to you:
[Undergraduate Bulletin](#)